

SUBMISSION TYPE

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Employer-Focused Interventions to Reduce Age Discrimination Against Older Workers

SHORTENED TITLE

Generational Differences in Employers' Age Bias

ABSTRACT

This study addresses an important but neglected topic by investigating whether employers' generational cohorts (Baby Boomers–Generation Z) are associated with differences in age-based discrimination. Drawing on System Justification Theory, we examine the psychological mechanisms that may help explain differences across generational cohorts in rationalizations for bias. Pilot data and expected results suggest that younger employers may exhibit stronger bias against older candidates but may also be more responsive to theory-based de-biasing interventions.

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Employer-Focused Interventions to Reduce Age Discrimination Against Older Workers: Evidence and Intervention Approaches

INTRODUCTION

The “silver tsunami”—the rapid aging of the global workforce—is no longer a future forecast but an unfolding reality (Rudolph et al., 2021; Lyons et al., 2015). This irreversible demographic shift is not only changing “who works,” but also reshaping “how organizations work” (Kooij et al., 2020; Waldman, 2021; Joshi et al., 2011). Consider this scenario: a senior employee watches as a young manager introduces a “modernization initiative” that quietly redefines his years of accumulated experience as “obsolete.” This underlying tension is not an isolated case; rather, it captures a troubling paradox: the need for intergenerational collaboration within organizations, yet the intensification of age discrimination.

Previous research, including extensive studies on the manifestations, consequences, and interventions of workplace ageism (Truxillo et al., 2015; Rudolph et al., 2017; Smola & Sutton, 2002), has predominantly treated employers as a homogeneous group. However, we question this prevailing assumption by suggesting that a neglected factor—the generational cohort membership of employers themselves—may be associated with differences in age-related attitudes and behaviors. The divergent values and managerial philosophies of employers from different generations—such as Baby Boomers, Generation X, and Millennials—may therefore represent a potentially meaningful source of variation. If these differences shape how they perceive and implement age-inclusive policies, have we underestimated the role of generational cohort differences in both the formation of and intervention in age discrimination? Our work seeks to examine how differences across employers' generational cohorts may influence the design and implementation of anti-bias interventions targeting older employees. We further aim to explore how organizations can

develop interventions that bridge, rather than exacerbate, generational divides.

Future research should be devoted to understanding how digital technologies may shape age discrimination in the workplace. On the one hand, digital transformation could exacerbate age discrimination—for instance, 76% of technology practitioners acknowledge the presence of age bias within the industry (CMIs, 2023), and Baby Boomers may tend to overemphasize seniority over technical proficiency. On the other hand, empirical investigations into technology-enabled interventions remain limited in scope (Cox et al., 2010).

LITERATURE REVIEW

Age discrimination can be conceptualized as stereotyping, prejudice, and unfair treatment based on age (Burnes et al., 2019; Posthuma & Campion, 2007). It stems from "taste-based discrimination" (Lahey, 2008) and typically manifests in reduced opportunities for occupational training (Grima, 2011), along with a decline in career self-efficacy and a weakening of intergenerational knowledge sharing (Fasbender & Gerpott, 2021). This phenomenon is embedded within broader social and organizational structures (Chang et al., 2020). Given its pervasive nature, age discrimination significantly impacts various workplace outcomes (Chou & Choi, 2011; Bal et al., 2011). As global aging accelerates, older workers' labor force participation rises, yet workplace age discrimination remains overlooked. This study addresses a notable gap in the literature on interventions to reduce age discrimination, with a particular focus on potential differences across employers' generational cohorts in how such measures are implemented. Drawing upon System Justification Theory (SJT), the present research aims to elucidate the underlying psychological mechanisms that may drive variation across employers from different generational cohorts, thereby providing a theoretical basis for the development of more effective intervention strategies.

System Justification Theory (SJT; Jost & Banaji, 1994; Jost, Banaji, & Nosek, 2004)

offers a robust theoretical lens for understanding the persistence of age discrimination. The theory posits that humans possess a pervasive ideological motive to defend, bolster, and rationalize the status quo, even when it operates against their own personal or group interests. At an implicit, unconscious level, this system-justifying motive can lead members of disadvantaged groups to internalize feelings of inferiority, producing what has been termed false consciousness. Paradoxically, those most negatively affected by the system may exhibit the strongest tendencies to defend it. From this perspective, age discrimination can be understood as the outcome of a broader psychological mechanism aimed at maintaining existing social structures: not only may employers unconsciously reinforce age-based discrimination, but older employees may also passively accept or rationalize such discriminatory norms, thereby alleviating the anxiety, guilt, and uncertainty associated with challenging the status quo (Jost & Hunyady, 2003).

Recent studies have shown that age discrimination in the work environment affects older employees' outcomes. According to System Justification Theory, older employees may passively accept discriminatory norms, while employers across different generations reinforce age discrimination through cohort-specific rationalizations. Regarding job satisfaction, older employees may internalize the perceived "rationality" of age discrimination to reduce cognitive dissonance. This internalization reduces job satisfaction and intensifies mental fatigue (Marchiondo et al., 2017), eventually leading to a self-defeating adaptive strategy over time (Griffin et al., 2016).

In terms of withdrawal behavior, system-maintenance logic drives employees facing discrimination to prioritize passive withdrawal over active resistance. This dynamic is reflected in higher risks of long-term sick leave among workers experiencing discrimination (Viitasalo & Nätti, 2015), while also increasing the likelihood of leaving the workforce without necessarily changing retirement intentions (Griffin et al., 2016). Regarding task

performance, although older employees are frequently stereotyped as ineffective (Harris et al., 2018), empirical evidence primarily indicates that they may be less willing to participate in training (Lamont et al., 2015; Ng & Feldman, 2012). In addition, research shows that older women face particularly severe age discrimination in the job market, with employers evaluating their skills below their actual capabilities (Berde & Mágó, 2022).

These findings highlight the diverse impacts of age discrimination on older employees and underscore the importance of examining employment discrimination (J. N. Lahey & Oxley, 2021). Employers' attitudes play a crucial role in shaping these adverse outcomes (Axelrad et al., 2021). Paradoxically, organizations may attribute discrimination-induced performance issues to age-related deficits in order to maintain organizational stability (Kunze et al., 2010). Therefore, workplace interventions targeting employer practices are critical for addressing age discrimination and promoting organizational development.

Research has shown that brief attitudinal interventions (Pinkas, 2018) and de-biasing interventions (Kleissner & Jahn, 2020) can reduce age discrimination in hiring decisions. However, informational warnings appear to be effective only for older male job seekers (Döbrich et al., 2014). This limited effectiveness for older female employees may stem from gender discrimination. Notably, both explicit and implicit age cues reduce older job seekers' hiring prospects, particularly in non-targeted recruitment contexts (Kleissner & Jahn, 2020). Longer-term interventions, such as collaborative measures, not only reduce age discrimination, but also sustain improvements in performance expectations for up to six months (Schloegel et al., 2016). At the same time, identity-based training can foster empathy, while knowledge-based training challenges age-ability stereotypes (Burmeister, 2020). Overall, although existing interventions contribute to reducing age discrimination in the workplace, their effectiveness remains limited when generational differences among employers are not considered.

Despite evidence that generational differences influence employers' selection decisions (Gabrielova & Buchko, 2021), few studies have empirically examined how these differences relate to discriminatory behavior toward older employees (Raymer et al., 2017). The present research addresses this gap by investigating generational differences in discriminatory practices among employers—including Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, and Generation Z—and aims to inform the design of more effective workplace interventions tailored to generational differences.

HYPOTHESIS

Study 1: Audit Experiment

This study examines age discrimination in real-world hiring and how it varies across employer generational cohort.

A substantial body of empirical research demonstrates that age discrimination is pervasive in hiring processes, significantly reducing the likelihood that older applicants receive interview invitations. Evidence from audit and survey experiments indicates that callback rates decline sharply once applicants enter their forties, with the gap widening further near retirement age, and these adverse effects are particularly pronounced for female applicants (Carlsson & Eriksson, 2019). When employers are unable to directly access age information, these differences are attenuated, suggesting that discrimination primarily arises from stereotype activation triggered by age cues (Neumark, 2024). Cross-national comparative studies further reveal that, regardless of country or industry context, older candidates consistently receive lower employability ratings than their younger counterparts. Importantly, providing counter-stereotypical information, such as learning ability or innovation potential, does not significantly alter employers' evaluations (Lössbroek, Lancee, van der Lippe, & Schippers, 2021).

This highlights the “stubborn” and non-rational nature of age bias, suggesting that providing corrective information alone may be insufficient, and that interventions must address the source of decision-making biases, such as employers’ generational cohort membership. Similarly, analyses combining natural and survey experiments show that older job seekers have significantly lower probabilities of reemployment after unemployment, with the age penalty particularly pronounced in blue-collar occupations (Oesch, 2019). Systematic reviews and meta-analyses show that age discrimination in hiring is comparable in magnitude to race- and disability-based discrimination, and is especially salient in European contexts (Lippens, Vermeiren, & Baert, 2023).

From a theoretical perspective, System Justification Theory (Jost & Banaji, 1994) posits that individuals and organizations are motivated to defend and rationalize existing social and economic hierarchies to maintain order and stability. In hiring contexts, this motivation manifests as the rationalization of beliefs such as “youth signals efficiency and innovation” and “older age signifies conservatism and low adaptability,” thereby unconsciously reproducing labor market inequalities. Collectively, these findings suggest that even when qualifications and competencies are equivalent, older candidates may be disadvantaged in recruitment due to systemic biases.

H1: Older candidates receive fewer interview invitations than younger candidates.

While age discrimination appears robust across contexts, the extent of bias may not be uniform across employer generational cohort. Theories of generational socialization suggest that individuals develop enduring work values and cognitive schemas shaped by the socioeconomic, technological, and cultural environments of their formative years (Cogin, 2012; Cennamo & Gardner, 2008; Gursoy, Chi, & Karadag, 2013). Compared with Baby Boomers and Generation X, who entered the workforce in an era valuing stability, tenure, and experience, Millennials and Generation Z have been socialized in a digital, innovation-driven

environment emphasizing flexibility, speed, and technological fluency. This orientation toward novelty and efficiency may inadvertently reinforce stereotypes that associate youth with adaptability and older age with obsolescence.

Empirical evidence supports this notion. Perry et al. (2017) demonstrated that generational membership shapes perceptions of applicants' motivation and adaptability: candidates described as "Baby Boomers" were rated as more motivated and adaptable than older (e.g., 60-year-old) applicants, whereas younger (Millennial) candidates were perceived most favorably. These generational differences in evaluative patterns indicate that the decision maker's generational cohort influences how age-related cues are interpreted during hiring.

System Justification Theory provides a general psychological motivation for defending existing social arrangements, while generational socialization may shape how different cohorts rationalize age hierarchies in organizations. For younger managers who grew up under "technology-first" and "disruptive innovation" discourses, systematically framing older employees as "less adaptable to technological change" may represent a direct way of rationalizing organizational power structures. Moreover, System Justification Theory suggests that younger generations, having grown up in periods of rapid technological change and meritocratic discourse, may be more motivated to rationalize existing age hierarchies by viewing older workers as less fit for dynamic, innovation-oriented environments (Bodner, 2009).

Together, these theoretical and empirical insights imply that employers' generational cohort membership functions as an important boundary condition in age discrimination. While all employers may rely on age-based stereotypes to some degree, Millennials and Generation Z employers, whose value systems prioritize innovation, digital competence, and adaptability, may exhibit stronger discrimination against older applicants in hiring decisions.

H2: Employer generational cohort moderates the effect of candidate age on interview invitations. Specifically, Millennials and Generation Z employers show stronger age discrimination against older candidates compared with Baby Boomers and Generation X.

[*Note: Candidate gender will be included as an exploratory variable to examine potential age-gender intersectional discrimination.]

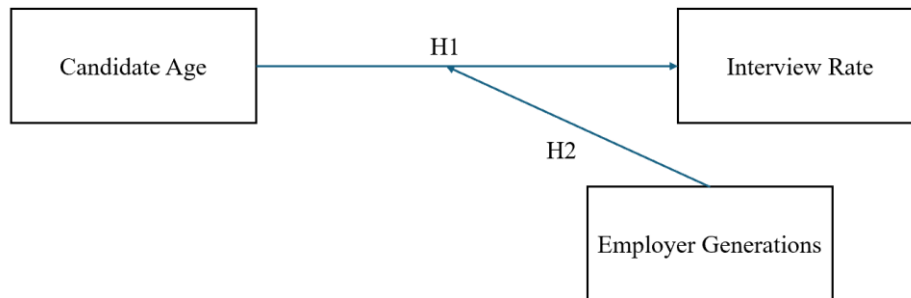


Figure 1: Study 1 Model

Study 2: Intervention Experiment

While System Justification Theory provides a general psychological motivation for maintaining age hierarchies in hiring (Jost & Banaji, 1994), generational socialization and social identity processes may shape how specific cohorts rationalize and respond to these hierarchies. Younger managers, having been socialized in environments emphasizing innovation, digital fluency, and meritocracy, may be more likely to perceive older workers as misaligned with organizational norms, which affects their baseline attitudes and responsiveness to interventions. Drawing on these insights and established theories of intergroup relations and attitude change, we propose that the effectiveness of interventions aimed at reducing age-based hiring bias may vary across employer generational cohort.

Evidence indicates that younger adults often hold more negative explicit attitudes toward older workers, a pattern linked to less frequent and less positive intergenerational contact in both private and professional domains (Sinclair et al., 2024; Gringart et al., 2008). From a social identity perspective, younger employees' ingroup identity is more sharply

demarcated from the outgroup of older workers, reinforcing negative stereotypes and increasing baseline bias (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Interventions grounded in Contact Theory and information/decision-making perspectives (Allport, 1954; van Knippenberg & Schippers, 2007) present counter-stereotypical experiences and decision-relevant evidence emphasizing diversity as a resource for innovation and performance, which may resonate more with younger employers whose values and cognitive schemas align with inclusion and evidence-based HR practices. Empirical studies support the notion that theory-based workshops and interventions can improve age-diverse workplace outcomes, particularly in younger workforces (Burmeister et al., 2021; Schloegel et al., 2016).

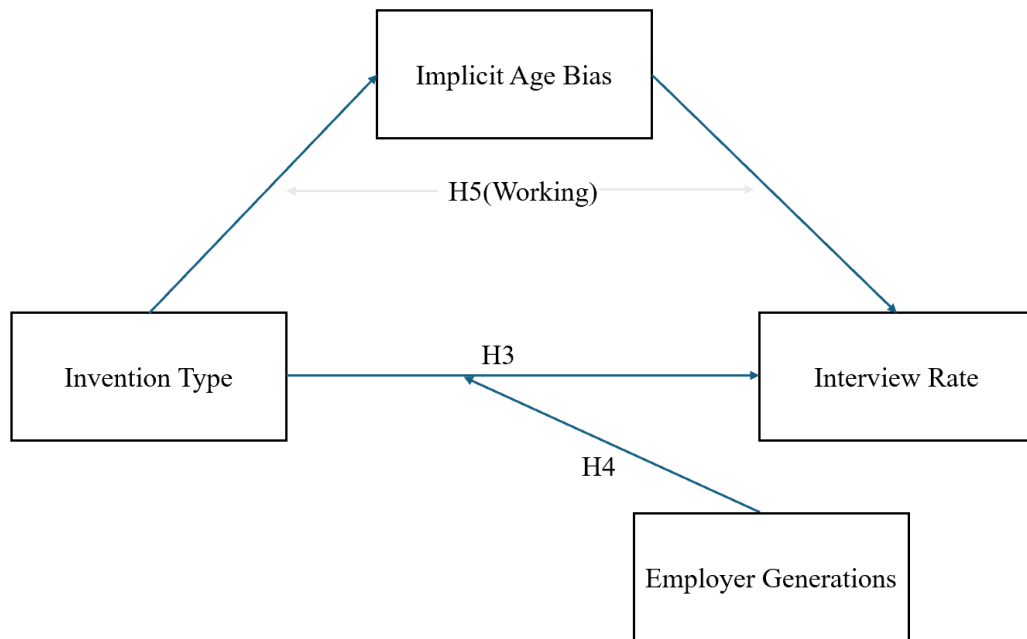


Figure 1: Study 2 Model

H3: Interventions increase hiring intentions for older candidates compared to the control group.

[Notes: De-biasing interventions provide explicit or indirect instructions to reduce discriminatory judgments (Döbrich et al., 2014; Kleissner & Jahn, 2021). Brief attitudinal

interventions involve short, multimedia or text-based exposure to counter-stereotypical information, perspective-taking, or imagined contact (Gringart, 2003; Pinkas, 2018)]

H4: *Employer generations cohort moderates intervention effects. Interventions are more effective for Millennials and Generation Z than for Baby Boomers and Generation X.*

H5 (Working hypothesis): *Implicit age bias mediates the effect of interventions on hiring intentions. Interventions reduce implicit age bias (measured via IAT), which in turn increases hiring intentions for older candidates.*

METHODS

Sample

Across both studies, data were collected from approximately 300 real-world job openings (Study 1) and 100-200 HR professionals (Study 2). An a priori power analysis conducted using G*Power 3.1 indicated that a minimum of 180 observations per study would provide adequate statistical power ($f = .25$, $\alpha = .05$, $1 - \beta = .80$) to detect medium-sized effects. The combined dataset allows examination of both behavioral (field) and attitudinal (experimental) evidence of generational differences.

Research Design and Procedure

The audit experiment employed a 2 (applicant age: young vs. older) $\times$ 4 (employer generational cohort: Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, Generation Z) factorial design. The primary outcome variable was the interview invitation rate (callback rate), with covariates including applicant gender and job type. The intervention experiment used a 2 (applicant age: young vs. older) $\times$ 3 (intervention type: de-biasing, brief attitude, control) between-subjects design.

Résumés were matched on qualifications, skills, and work experience but varied in graduation year and career length to signal applicant age, representing candidates below

versus above 50 years old, a commonly used threshold for defining older applicants in labor market research (Sinclair et al., 2023).

Following research in organizational demography, generational characteristics of organizations can be approximated through leadership cohort composition and founding period, as these factors shape managerial values, HR practices, and organizational culture. Accordingly, Employer **generational cohort** was estimated using company-level proxy indicators:

- the average age of senior managers identified through LinkedIn or company websites.
- company founding year
- industry-level HR demographic data.

These indicators were combined to assign employers to generational cohorts (Baby Boomers, Generation X, Millennials, Generation Z). Participants evaluated four résumés that varied by applicant age and gender after receiving one of the interventions delivered via text or multimedia lasting 10–15 minutes. Post-task measures included the Ageism Attitude Scale (AAS) and an age-focused Implicit Association Test (IAT; Greenwald, McGhee, & Schwartz, 1998) to assess implicit bias.

Data were analyzed using logistic regression for the audit experiment and linear mixed-effects models for the intervention experiment, testing main and interaction effects of candidate age, employer generational cohort, and intervention type, with mediation analyses examining whether changes in implicit bias explained intervention effects.

Coding, Technical Procedures, and Pilot Results

Callback data (Study 1) and attitudinal measures (Study 2) were analyzed using SPSS 27, with logistic regression, linear mixed-effects models, and PROCESS used to test interaction and mediation effects.

Pilot test results support the hypothesized patterns: younger employers (Millennials and

Generation Z) showed stronger bias against older candidates in hiring decisions, but they also responded more positively to de-biasing interventions, exhibiting increased intentions to hire older candidates. Older generations displayed lower baseline bias and smaller intervention effects, consistent with the moderation predictions (H2, H4).

DISCUSSION

This working-in-progress study highlights how employer generational identity shapes age discrimination and intervention effectiveness, extending System Justification Theory by identifying generational socialization as a boundary condition. Preliminary findings suggest that interventions—de-biasing prompts, brief attitudinal exercises, and workshops—can improve older candidates' hiring prospects, with differential effects across generations. Practically, organizations should tailor anti-age-discrimination initiatives to managerial courts.

This study has several limitations. First, the analyses rely partly on preliminary and pre-experimental data, and the intervention effects examined here capture only short-term attitudinal responses. Future research should investigate whether such interventions produce sustained behavioral changes and test their effectiveness in real organizational settings. Second, employer generational cohort in Study 1 is approximated using organizational proxy indicators (e.g., company founding year and the age composition of senior managers). While this approach is common in audit studies where individual decision-maker characteristics are not directly observable, these proxies may not fully capture the generational identity of hiring managers. Finally, because the data are cross-sectional, generational differences should be interpreted cautiously. Observed differences between employer cohorts may reflect age effects (life-stage differences) or period effects (shared historical contexts), rather than true cohort-based generational differences. Longitudinal or repeated cross-sectional designs would be required to disentangle these influences more rigorously.

Future research should explore how digital transformation and generational differences jointly shape age-related bias in the workplace. Algorithmic recruitment systems may reproduce “taste-based” discrimination through historical hiring data, while generational differences in employer attitudes may further amplify these biases. Understanding both behavioral and technological mechanisms is therefore essential for developing interventions that address attitudinal and algorithmic discrimination.

CONCLUSION

This research highlights how employer generational identity shapes age discrimination and intervention effectiveness. By combining audit and experimental methods, it identifies mechanisms driving bias and tests strategies to improve older workers' hiring outcomes. Findings offer practical guidance for designing generationally sensitive, evidence-based interventions to foster age-inclusive workplaces in increasingly intergenerational contexts.

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